THEORY LAB · 01

Nobody remembers your paper.

It was correct. It passed review. It has been cited eleven times, mostly by you.

Murray Davis explained why in 1971.

THE CLAIM

Truth is table stakes.

“A theorist is considered great, not because his theories are true, but because they are interesting.”

Everything published is supposed to be true. Truth doesn't distinguish you from anyone.

So what does?

THE MECHANISM

A proposition is interesting when it denies an assumption the reader already holds.

Not a strongly held one: that produces “that's absurd.”

Not a non-existent one: that produces “that's irrelevant.”

A moderately held one. Believed, but never examined.

DAVIS'S VOCABULARY

Four terms that carry the whole argument

The assumption-ground

What the audience routinely takes for granted and has never examined. It is the surface a proposition has to push against to be interesting at all.

The interestingness band

Deny a moderately held assumption and you get “that's interesting.” Deny a strongly held one: “that's absurd.” Deny one nobody holds: “that's irrelevant.”

The index of the interesting

Davis's catalogue of twelve moves by which a proposition can deny an assumption, reversing causation, composition, evaluation, co-variation and nine others.

The second test

A finding is only truly interesting if it also denies the significance of what the audience is currently doing. Fail it and the response is “so what?”

Davis's three-step form of a research paper

1 Articulate what the audience takes for granted, “It has long been thought...”

2 Deny it, “But this is false...”

3 Spend the body proving the old assumption wrong and the new one right

A DOCUMENTED CASE

The number everyone quotes about Grameen Bank

Grameen reported repayment rates of 97–98%, far above the state development banks it displaced. The figure travelled everywhere.

It was also computed on non-standard definitions: loans counted as in default only years after the due date, arrears divided by a rapidly growing portfolio, refinanced loans reported as current. Morduch's recalculation puts it nearer 92%.

The achievement is real. The number is not comparable to a commercial bank's loan-loss figure, and almost nobody who repeats it knows that.

Morduch (1999), Journal of Economic Literature, 37(4), 1569–1614

The two-minute test

YOU HAVE A DESCRIPTION

Write what your reader currently believes.

Write your finding underneath it.

If both can be true at once, with no tension, you have a description. Correct, competent, forgettable.

YOU HAVE A CONTRIBUTION

If your second sentence makes the first one WRONG, you have a contribution.

Interestingness is not a property of your finding. It is a relationship between your finding and what your reader already believes.

SOURCES

Davis, M. S. (1971). That's interesting! Towards a phenomenology of sociology and a sociology of phenomenology. Philosophy of the Social Sciences, 1, 309–344.

Morduch, J. (1999). The microfinance promise. Journal of Economic Literature, 37(4), 1569–1614.

Davis's essay also catalogues twelve specific moves by which a proposition can deny an assumption. Those are in the first comment.

THE QUESTION

What is the one sentence your field believes that your work makes harder to believe?

If you can't write it, that is the finding.

Next Saturday: the five things reviewers routinely mistake for theory, and why two of them are in almost every paper.

Tell me in the comments